Acmad Umpa Omar Jr

Acmad Umpa Omar Jr. (born 24 May 1970, Iligan City) is a Brigadier General of the Philippine Air Force (PAF) and one of the most consequential figures in the intersection of military affairs and national legislation in the Philippines today. Since 05 March 2021, he has served as the Chief of the Office for Legislative Affairs (OLA) of the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP), the officer primarily responsible for representing the AFP's interests before both houses of the Philippine Congress and the Commission on Appointments. A seasoned combat helicopter pilot with 3,000 flying hours to his name, a holder of three graduate degrees, and a proud member of the Maranao community from the Lanao region of Mindanao, BGen. Omar is a rare figure in Philippine military history. His career is the story of a man who learned to fight in the skies above Mindanao, lead across some of the AFP's most demanding commands, and then take that same energy into the deliberative halls of the legislature, where some of the country's most significant defense and security laws of the past several years bear his fingerprints.

Early Life and Heritage

Acmad Umpa Omar Jr. was born on **24 May 1970** in Iligan City, a city that has long sat at the crossroads between the Christian and Muslim worlds of Northern Mindanao. He is of **Maranao** descent, belonging to the "People of the Lake," the ethnolinguistic community historically rooted at the shores of Lake Lanao in the Lanao region. The Maranao are known for their warrior tradition, their intricate arts (particularly the okir), and a deep cultural code of honor that prizes dignity, excellence, and the defense of one's name and community. Those values were not abstract for the young Acmad. They were lived.

He took his early schooling in the city that shaped him. He completed his elementary education at **Diliman Preparatory School** and his secondary education at **La Salle Academy, Iligan City**, a school known for forming young men of discipline and character. After finishing high school, he entered the **University of Santo Tomas (UST)** in Manila, where he was pursuing a degree in Civil Engineering and was already in his second year of college when he made a decision that would change the course of his life. In 1990, he left his engineering studies behind and walked into the Philippine Military Academy as a plebe. He never looked back.

Education and Academic Formation

Philippine Military Academy

He entered the **Philippine Military Academy (PMA)** in 1990 as a plebe and graduated in 1994 as a commissioned officer of the Philippine Air Force with the **"Bantay Laya" Class of 1994**, a batch whose name, meaning "Guardian of Freedom," set the tone for everything that followed.

Military Training and Specialization

Fresh out of the Academy, he immediately threw himself into the specialized training pipeline that turns commissioned officers into Air Force professionals. He completed the **Basic Air Force Officers Course (BAFOC)**, the prerequisite that every Air Force officer must go through, and then moved on to pilot training at the **Philippine Air Force Flying School (PAFFS)**.

At PAFFS, he didn't just complete the course. He topped it. In 1996, he graduated and was conferred the prestigious **Vicente Rivera Award for Number One in Instrument Flying**, a recognition given to the cadet who demonstrates the highest level of proficiency in flying on instruments. That kind of distinction early in a pilot's career says a lot about the officer you're dealing with.

His training didn't stop there. In 2003, he traveled to **Lackland Air Force Base in Texas, USA**, where he completed the **United States Air Force (USAF) Advanced Logistics Readiness Operation Course**, deepening his expertise in the logistical backbone of air operations. Back home, he completed the **AFP Intelligence Officers Collection Course**, the **PAF Squadron Officers Course**, and the **Command and General Staff College** at Camp Aguinaldo, Quezon City, all of which are key rungs on the ladder toward senior leadership.

He also brought international exposure into areas beyond pure military operations. He attended **Civil-Military Operations training in Stockholm, Sweden**, and the **Civil-Military International Cooperation Course in Fort Dickson, Malaysia**, building the cross-cultural, inter-agency sensibility that would later define his work as a legislative affairs officer. Additional professional courses included Defense Resource Management Training and Finance Accountable Officer programs, rounding out a training record that covers the full spectrum of modern military leadership.

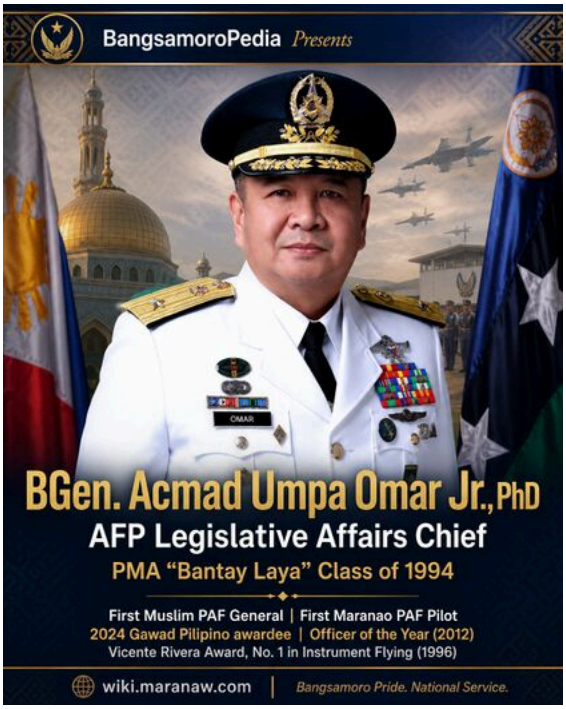
Graduate Academic Degrees

BGen. Omar's commitment to education didn't end with his commission. Over the course of his career, he pursued and completed three graduate degrees, making him one of the more academically credentialed flag officers in the AFP today.

He earned a **Master in National Security Administration (MNSA)** from the **National Defense College of the Philippines (NDCP)**, the AFP's premier institution for strategic and security studies. He also holds a **Master in Public Administration, Major in Development and Security (MPA-DevSec)**, from the **Development Academy of the Philippines (DAP)**. Most recently, he completed a **Doctorate in Development Administration, Major in Public Governance**, from **Philippine Christian University (PCU)**.

Together, these degrees reflect a career-long effort to understand not just how to command, but how institutions work, how governance functions, and how security and development intersect. That grounding shows clearly in the work he has done as Chief, OLA.

BGen. Acmad Umpa Omar Jr., PAF



Born	24 May 1970, Iligan City, Philippines
Ethnicity	Maranao (Bangsamoro)
Branch	Philippine Air Force (PAF)
Rank	Brigadier General
Current Position	Chief, Office for Legislative Affairs (OLA), AFP (05 March 2021 to present)
Specialty	Combat Helicopter Pilot
Flying Hours	3,000 (Accident-Free to 2,500 hours)
Academy	Philippine Military Academy (PMA)
Class	"Bantay Laya" Class of 1994
Graduate Degrees	MNSA (NDCP); MPA-DevSec (DAP); DDA-Public Governance (PCU)
Spouse	Dr. Melanie Sarmiento-Omar, FPSOUG

Military Career and Command Positions

Children	4 (1LT Jaafar, Atty. Gabriel Acmad, Raphael Hamzah, Zaina Arriana)
Notable Award	Vicente Rivera Award, No. 1 in Instrument Flying, PAFFS (1996); Officer of the Year (2012)

Over the course of 35 years in uniform, BGen. Omar has accumulated a command record that spans air operations, intelligence, search and rescue, combat deployments, and institutional management. Some of his major assignments include:

- **Commander, Tactical Operations Group of Sulu and Tawi-Tawi (TOG SULTAW)** — one of the AFP's most operationally demanding commands, covering a region historically central to internal security challenges in the Southern Philippines.
- **Commander, Trilateral Air Patrol (TAP), Indonesia-Malaysia-Philippines (INDOMALPHI)** — a multinational air patrol arrangement among the three neighboring countries, reflecting BGen. Omar's capacity for regional security cooperation.
- **Deputy Assistant Chief of Staff for Reservist and Retirees Affairs, OA9**
- **Director for Operations, Tactical Operations Wing Western Mindanao (TOWWESMIN)**
- **Commander, PAF Search and Rescue Squadron**
- **Director, PAF Inspection Division**
- **Air Force Inspector General (AFIG)** — a role that requires both moral authority and institutional knowledge, as the AFIG is responsible for ensuring the Air Force maintains its standards and values.
- **Director, Plans and Program, PAF**
- **Assistant Chief of Air Staff for Personnel, OA1**
- **Commanding Officer, Executive Officer/Plans, Program, and Budget Unit, AFP Pension Gratuity Management Center**
- **Chief, Management Fiscal Office, AFP Pension Gratuity Management Center**

Each of these positions added a layer to his understanding of how the AFP works, both at the tactical and institutional levels. By the time he assumed the OLA post in 2021, he brought to it a career's worth of operational credibility, administrative experience, and the kind of personal rapport that only 35 years of service can build.

Flying Career

One of the defining dimensions of BGen. Omar's identity as an Air Force officer is his life in the cockpit. He is a **seasoned combat helicopter pilot** who has accumulated **3,000 flying hours** over the course of his career, a figure that puts him among the AFP's most experienced aerial operators.

That record includes the **2,500 Flying Hours Accident-Free Award**, a recognition of not just the volume of flight time he has logged but the discipline and professionalism with which he has done so. He holds the **PAF Command Rating Pilots Badge**, one of the Air Force's highest distinctions for pilots.

His flying career began with the Vicente Rivera Award at PAFFS in 1996 and continued through decades of operational deployments, including his time commanding TOG SULTAW, where helicopter operations are often central to the mission. That cockpit experience grounds everything else about him. It gives him a kind of credibility that no desk assignment can manufacture.

Service as Chief, Office for Legislative Affairs, AFP

BGen. Omar assumed designation as Chief of the **Office for Legislative Affairs (OLA)** of the AFP on **05 March 2021**, and his tenure in that role has been one of the most productive in the office's history.

The OLA's job is both simple to describe and difficult to execute. It serves as the primary interface between the AFP, one of the country's largest and most complex institutions, and the Philippine Congress, the body that ultimately controls the AFP's budget, legal framework, and policy environment. The Chief of OLA is, in practice, the AFP's voice to the legislature. That voice has to be credible, consistent, and well-informed.

BGen. Omar has brought all three to the role. He has built what his colleagues describe as a genuinely strong rapport with members of both the Senate and the House of Representatives, as well as with the **Commission on Appointments (CA)**, the body that confirms presidential appointments to senior military and civilian positions. That relationship didn't happen by accident. It was built through sustained, respectful engagement, and through delivering on commitments.

A concrete expression of that relationship has been the construction of a new facility that will serve as the headquarters for the OLA team and satellite offices for the Senate and House of Representatives. The building, which includes a VIP lounge, conference room, library, and roof deck, is designed to function as a hub of operational coordination between the AFP and its congressional stakeholders. It is, in a very practical sense, a monument to the kind of trust BGen. Omar has built between the two institutions during his tenure.

Legislative Achievements

Perhaps the most tangible measure of BGen. Omar's impact as Chief, OLA, is the list of laws that were enacted under his leadership. These are not minor administrative measures. They include some of the most consequential legislation affecting the AFP, national security, and Philippine sovereignty in recent years:

- **Anti-Terrorism Act of 2020 (Republic Act 11479)** — the law that defines and penalizes terrorism and establishes the legal framework for counter-terrorism operations.
- **Republic Act 11709** — prescribing fixed terms for key AFP officers, increasing the mandatory retirement age of Generals and Flag Officers, and providing for a more effective attrition system.
- **Republic Act 11939** — the amendment to RA 11709, refining its provisions.
- **Defense Acquisition Act (Republic Act 12009)** — governing how the AFP procures defense equipment and systems, a critical piece of legislation for the AFP Modernization Program.
- **Self-Reliant Defense Posture Act (Republic Act 12024)** — promoting the development of a domestic defense industry to reduce the AFP's dependence on foreign military equipment.
- **Philippine Maritime Zone Act (Republic Act 12064)** — defining and asserting the country's maritime zones, a measure of significant strategic importance given the Philippines' ongoing territorial challenges.
- **Archipelagic Sea Lanes Act (Republic Act 12065)** — establishing the legal basis for the designation and management of sea lanes through Philippine archipelagic waters.
- **Free Legal Assistance Act (Republic Act 12177)** — providing free legal assistance to AFP personnel, a welfare measure that directly benefits the men and women in uniform.

Each of these laws required sustained legislative advocacy, careful relationship management, and the ability to communicate complex security and defense concerns in terms that legislators and their staff could understand and act on. That's what BGen. Omar has done, consistently, across his years in the role.

Family

BGen. Omar is married to **Dr. Melanie Sarmiento-Omar, FPSOUG**, a fellow professional whose academic and medical credentials reflect a household that takes excellence seriously. They are blessed with four children.

Their eldest, **1LT Jaafar Omar**, is a graduate of the Philippine Military Academy **Class of 2018**, carrying on the family's tradition of military service into the next generation. Their second child, **Atty. Gabriel Acmad Omar**, has pursued a career in law. Their younger children are **Raphael Hamzah** and **Zaina Arriana**.

The family is, in its own way, a reflection of BGen. Omar's values: service, education, and the kind of groundedness that only comes from knowing where you come from.

Awards and Recognition

BGen. Omar's 35 years of service have been recognized through a long and varied list of military honors, commendations, and special recognitions:

- Three (3) **Outstanding Achievement Medals**
- **Distinguished Service Star**
- **Distinguished Service Medal**
- **Bronze Cross Medal**
- **Silver Wing Medal**
- **Combat Kagitingan Badge**
- **Military Merit Medals**
- **Long Service Medal Achievement**
- **Military Commendation Medals**
- **Military Civic Action Medal**
- **Visayas and Mindanao Campaign Medal**
- **People Power II Award**
- **Disaster Relief Badges**
- **Marksmanship Badge**
- **Inspector General's Badge**
- **Intelligence Badge**
- **Wing Commander's Well Done Award**
- **Presidential Streamer Award**
- **Officer of the Year Award** for 2012
- **PAF Command Rating Pilots Badge**
- **2,500 Flying Hours Accident-Free Award**
- Forty-two (42) commendations
- Thirty (30) certificates of appreciation and recognition

That is not a short list. It's the accumulated recognition of a career lived fully and in service to others.

Legacy

BGen. Acmad Umpa Omar Jr. carries two legacies, and both of them matter.

The first is institutional. Within the AFP, he has demonstrated that the Office for Legislative Affairs is not just a liaison function. It is a strategic asset. Under his leadership, the office has been the fulcrum on which some of the most important defense legislation of the decade has turned. He has built lasting relationships, created permanent infrastructure, and expanded the OLA's capacity to serve the AFP's legislative needs long after his own tenure ends.

The second legacy is personal and communal. As a senior Maranao officer in the Philippine Air Force, BGen. Omar represents something that goes beyond rank and position. In a country where Muslim Filipinos have historically been underrepresented in the national military establishment, a Brigadier General from Iligan City with a Maranao heart, a combat pilot's record, and a doctorate is not a small thing. For the young people of the Bangsamoro who are watching, he is proof that you don't have to set aside who you are to serve the nation at the highest level. You carry it with you. And it makes you stronger.

He leads by what he calls **Integrity, Professionalism, and Excellence**, the three values he has consistently put at the center of his leadership philosophy. Those aren't catchphrases for BGen. Omar. They're the operating system.

See Also

- Philippine Air Force
- Armed Forces of the Philippines
- Philippine Military Academy
- Bangsamoro
- Maranao people
- National Defense College of the Philippines
- Development Academy of the Philippines
- AFP Modernization Program
- Commission on Appointments (Philippines)

External Links

- Philippine Air Force Official Website (https://www.paf.mil.ph/)
- Armed Forces of the Philippines Official Website (https://www.afp.mil.ph/)
- National Defense College of the Philippines (https://www.ndcp.edu.ph/)

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